Nature of Qualitative Research

Chapter 6

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Primary Data

Qualitative research

An unstructured, primarily exploratory design based on small samples, intended to provide depth, insight and understanding.

Qual

Quantitative Research

Research techniques that seek to quantify data and, typically, apply some form of measurement and statistical analysis.

Quant

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Critics of Qualitative Research

- Many quantitative researchers dismiss qualitative studies completely as giving no valid findings

- Qualitative researchers ignore representative sampling, with their findings based on a single case or only a few cases

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Defenders of Qualitative Research

- Some qualitative researchers, who firmly reject statistical and other quantitative methods as yielding shallow or completely misleading information.
- They believe that to understand cultural values and consumer behavior, especially in its full contextual richness, requires interviewing or intensive field observation
- Qualitative techniques they see as being the only methods of data collection sensitive enough to capture the nuances of consumer attitudes, motives and behavior.

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Both Can Work Together

- There are circumstances were qualitative research can be used to present detailed descriptions that cannot be measured in a quantifiable manner

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Nature of Qualitative Research

- Qualitative research encompasses a variety of methods that can be applied in a flexible manner, to enable participants to reflect upon and express their views or to observe their behaviour.

- Methods from psychology are used to gain access to deeper answers

- Methods from anthropology are used to see the world through the eyes of the subjects

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Why Qualitative Research

Preference and/or Experience of Researcher

- Some researchers have more experience or are just better for qualitative research
- Enjoy the challenges of qualitative research
- Training in anthropology, psychology and philosophy

Preference and/or Experience of Research User

- Some Decision makers prefer qualitative data
- Might lack knowledge in statistical methods
- Work in creative fields such as product design or advertising

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Why Qualitative Research

Sensitive Information

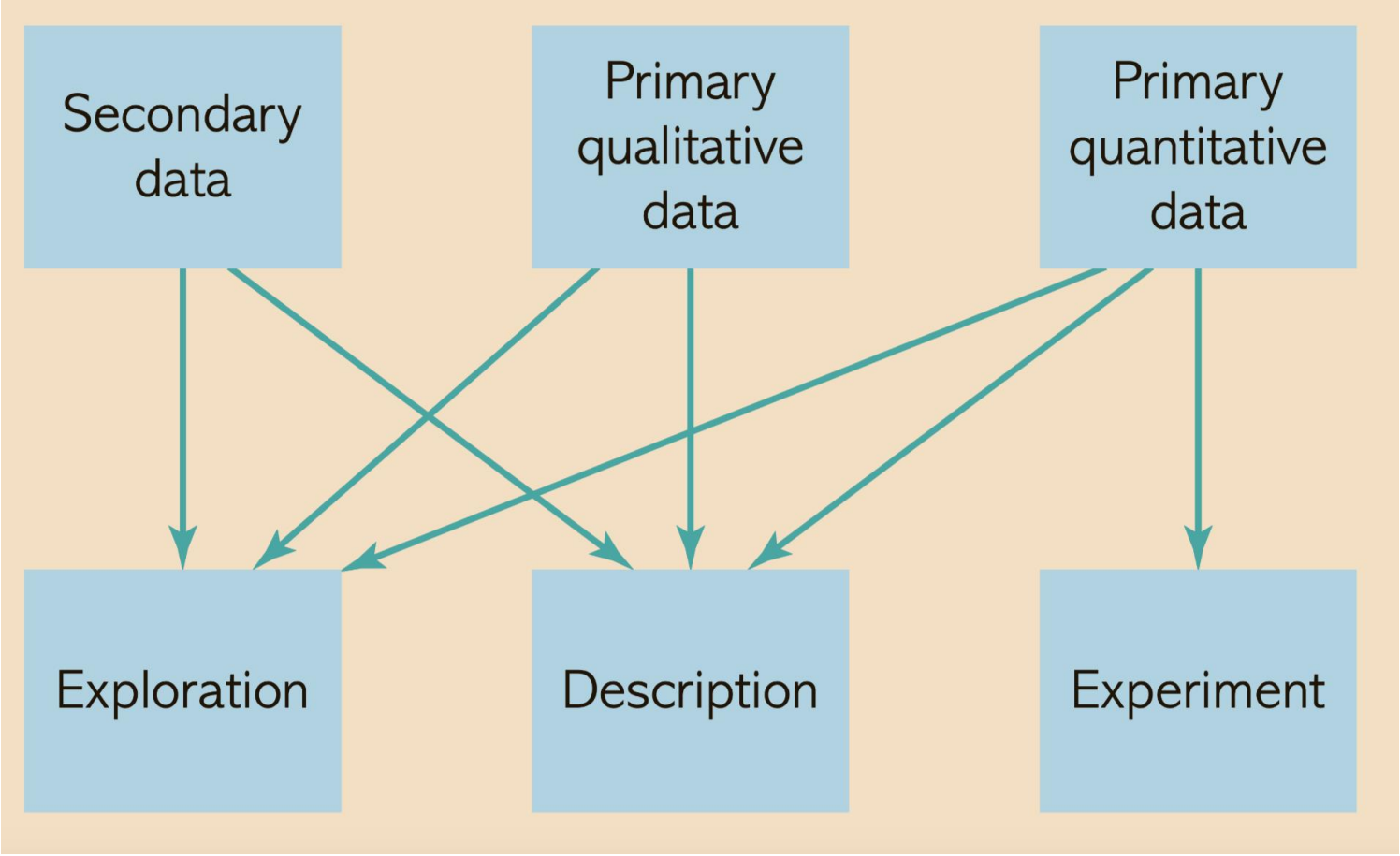
- Participants may be unwilling to answer or to give truthful answers to certain questions
- Qualitative Research techniques can build trust and may allow sensitive data to be elllicited

Subconscious Feeling

- The values, emotional drives and motivations residing at the subconscious level are disguised from the outer world by rationalization and other ego defenses.
- Why did you buy the expensive car?

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Classification of Marketing Research Data



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Why Qualitative Research

Complex Phenomena

- The nature of what participants are expected to describe may be difficult to capture with structured questions.
- They may not be able to clearly explain why they have these feelings or where these feelings are coming from.

The Holistic Method

- gain a comprehensive and complete picture of the whole context in which the phenomena of interest occur
- Different Methods work together

How good was the restaurant?

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Why Qualitative Research

Developing New Theory

- The development of “new” theory through a qualitative approach is called “grounded theory”

Interpretation

- Qualitative techniques as the final step in research design
- Large-scale surveys and audits often fail to clarify the underlying reasons for a set of findings.

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Philosophy Qualitative Research

Positivism

- The study of consumers and marketing phenomena should be ‘scientific’ in the manner of the natural sciences.

- Structured and Scientific

Interpretivist

- More open minded in its main idea

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Reality

Positivist

- Reality is “out there” to be captured
- The most effective and objective means possible to draw together information about this reality

Interpretivist

- Reality is dynamic, participant-constructed and evolving
- may be a wide array of interpretations of realities or social acts.

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Researcher-Participant

Positivist

- The participant as an ‘object’ to be measured in a reliable or consistent manner.
- Ask questions, get answers

Interpretivist

- The participants are “peers” or even “companions”
- Seek the right context and means of observing and questioning to suit individual participants

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Values

Positivist

- Sets aside his or her own personal values.
- Measurements of participants are being guided by established theoretical propositions.
- The task for the positivist is to remove any potential bias

Interpretivist

- Recognizes that their own values affect how they observe, question, probe and interpret.
- Reflect upon and realize the nature of their values and how these impact upon how they observe, question and interpret.

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Researcher Language

Positivist

- language in questioning that is uniformly recognized
- The positivist imposes a language and logic upon target participants in a reliable or consistent manner

Interpretivist

- Seeks to draw out the language and logic of target participants.
- The language used may differ between participants and develop in different ways as the interpretivist learns more about a topic and the nature of participants.

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Theory and Research Design

Positivist

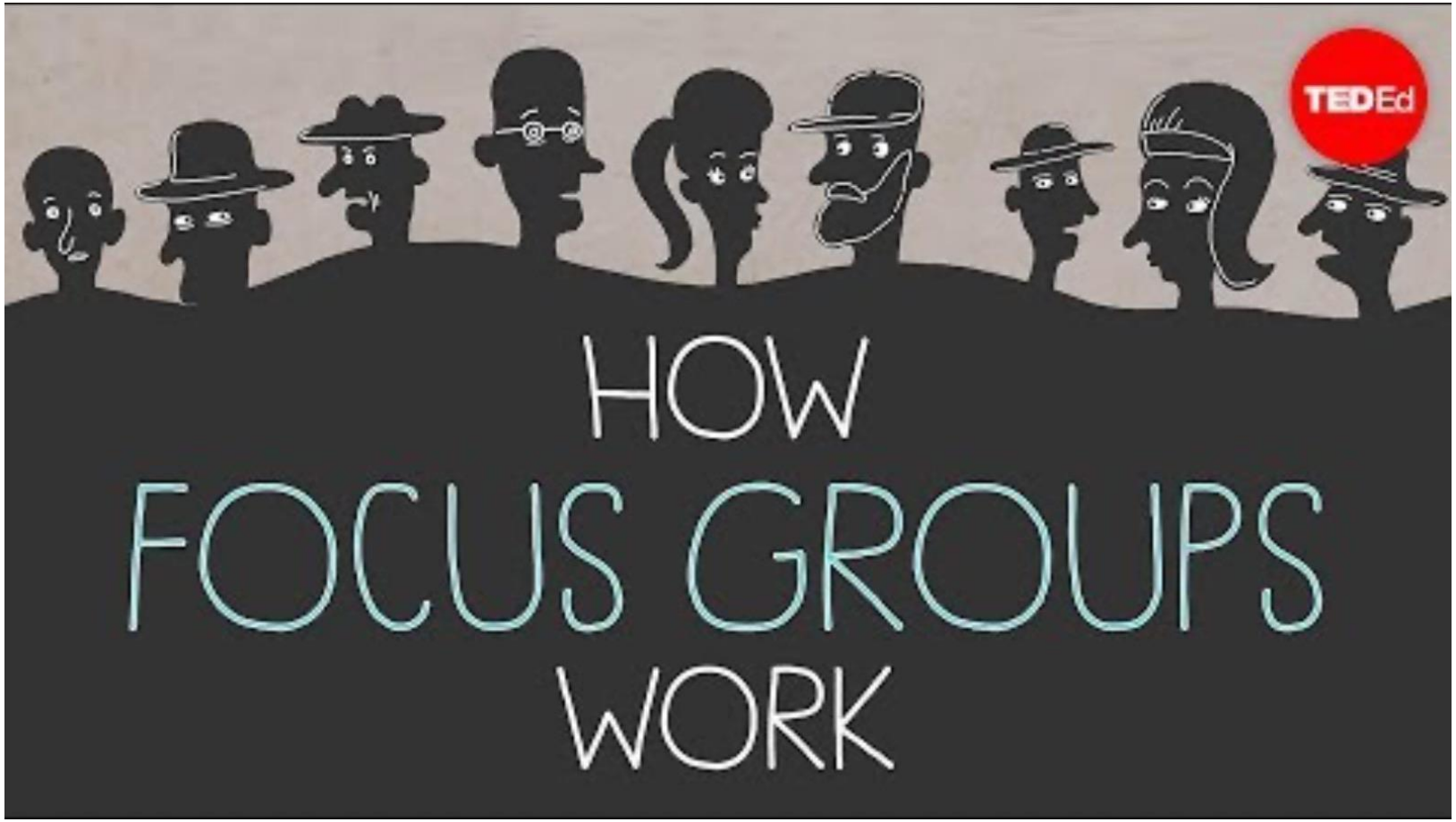
- The positivist seeks to establish causality
- seek to control extraneous variables and the environment in which an experiment takes place.
- Generalize findings to a target population

Interpretivist

- Learn from each step of the research process and adapt the research design as their learning develops
- Adopts an evolving research design
- Uses Theoretical sampling: Data-gathering driven by concepts derived from evolving theory and based on the concept of making comparisons.

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Focus Groups



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Types of Focus Groups

Cognitive (USA and Japan)

- The analysis or articulation has been worked on before
- interviews are largely meant to confirm or expand on known issues

Conative (European)

- Analysis taking place during and after the group
- Exploratory and group members being encouraged to take their own paths of discussion

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Focus Group Room

Bland and Boring

Observation Room

Communal



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Japanese Focus Groups

- The practices and reflexes in use in the West are at odds with the need at the heart of Japanese research orthodoxy to reduce the bias in the focus group.
- Free expression of opinion and having an opinion is a value in Western culture, whereas in Japan it is not.
- The successful application of home-visit and ethnography research in Japan demonstrates that, in relaxed and humanized conditions, consumers can talk more openly about their inner needs and private thoughts.

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Focus Group Example



https://youtu.be/xjHZsEcSqwo?si=agP7S5oxDC-u4w1Y

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Ethnographic Research

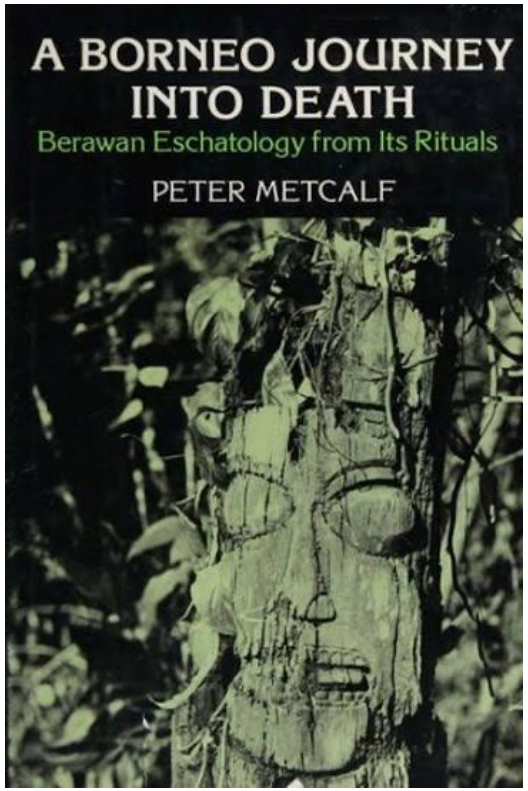
- **Ethnography** is a research approach based upon the observation of the customs, habits and differences between people in everyday situations.

- The focus of investigation is a detailed examination of a small number of cases rather than a large sample.

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Origins of Ethnography

- The origins of ethnography are in the work of nineteenth-century anthropologists who travelled to observe different pre-industrial cultures



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Ethnography Today

- They may work with cultural artefacts, such as written texts, or study recordings of interactions they did not observe at first hand
- Relies upon entering participants' natural-life worlds, at home, while shopping, at leisure and in the workplace.
- Observing how products may impact upon the consumers' experience and their ultimate buying behavior can be of great value to designers and marketers

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Aims Of Ethnography

- Seeing through the eyes of others.
- Description
- Contextualism
- Process
- Avoiding early use of theories and concepts
- Flexible research designs

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When is Ethnography Useful

- High-intensity situations
- Behavioural processes
- Memory inadequate
- Shame or reluctance

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Windows and Ethnography

- Microsoft Chief Design Anthropologist, Anne Kirah, observed 40 ordinary randomly chosen American families try to set up and use and Early Version of Windows XP
- These Families found the process of Windows XP frustrating
- First assumption was that the people chosen were “dumb” and not representative
- All the people testing Windows before were Tech Enthusiasts who volunteered

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"I am an observer; that is what an ethnographer is. It is not taking a list of questions you would otherwise ask online and, sitting in someone's kitchen, asking the same thing. I go to people's homes when they wake up and leave when they go to bed; I go with them. If they are changing a baby's nappy, I watch them do it. I once sat with a women who was ironing for five hours. I do not go into homes to study computers. I do not give a damn whether they have a computer or not. If you really want to know what makes people tick, and their motivations and aspirations, that is where innovation comes from. Do not ask them questions, listen to them."

Anne Kirah, Chief Design Anthropologist Microsoft

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LG Electronics

- LG wanted to figure out how people used appliances in daily life
- Combined video diaries, long interviews and ethnographic research

- Installed cameras in participants home to see how they used appliances

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Listening

- Listening involves the evaluation of naturally occurring conversations, behaviours and signals.
- The information that is elicited may or may not be guided, but it brings the voice of consumers' lives to brand.

- Researchers can now listen in "Conversational Webs" (reddit, twitter)

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Hennessey and African Americans

- Hennessey learned that black-planet members linked their personal website to Henessey's site
- Commissioned a survey of the members
- Survey described 8/10 of individuals as "high-value"
- Created new events and campaigns to target that specific group





"They wanna know who is my role model ,it's in a brown bottle"

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Netnography Nivea

- instituted a holistic **co-creation** process that included the app of **netnography.**
- Found online communities were use spoke about a numberof issues revolving around the buying, application and effectiveness of deodorants in their own language and with a distinct classification
- The consumer insights helped Nivea to develop a deep understanding of consumers, the language they use and what truly bothers them
- In the final step of the netnography, product designers joined the research team and helped to interpret and translate the consumer insights into initial products.

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Co-Creation

- The practice of developing new designs, including products or marketing communications, through collaboration with consumers.

LEGO:

- “Lego” started a project called “master-builders” where consumers were invited to help design products
- Thousands of people apply each year to help design new products
- Fans created unofficial websites where people can post new ideas

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Grounded Theory

- A qualitative approach to generating theory through the systematic and simultaneous process of data collection and analysis.

- Developed by Glaser and Strauss in the late 1950s

- Develop new ideas to verify them using quantitative methods

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Action Research

- Action research is a team research process, facilitated by a professional researcher(s), linking with decision makers and other stakeholders who together wish to improve particular situations.

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Action Research Origin

- Kurt Lewin was commissioned by the US authorities in their quest to use tripe as part of the regular daily diet of American families

- The research question was: ‘To what extent could American housewives be encouraged to use tripe rather than beef for family dinners?’
- Lewis trained a limited number of housewifes on how to cook tripe and then analyzed how this training changed their daily cooking techniques

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